

Week 7: Pantheism

BIG IDEA

Pantheism, the dominant Eastern worldview, teaches that god is in all and is all: a divine spark in everything, with no distinction between creator and creation. It has reached the West through karma, meditation, yoga, and Star Wars, and losing the Creator-creation distinction drives us straight back to idolatry.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- Pantheism dominates Eastern culture, but karma, meditation, yoga, and Star Wars' 'force' show it has made its way West, so students must learn to identify it.
- Pantheism says god is literally part of everything, rocks, trees, all of nature, a divine essence; this differs from the Holy Spirit dwelling in believers.
- The key word is distinction: naturalism says there is no God, pantheism says God exists but is not distinct from creation.
- At the Areopagus Paul helps the Stoics, who believed much like modern pantheists, see that God is personal and near yet distinct and other than us.
- Without distinction everything is as divine as God, so worshiping rocks and trees is no different; losing the distinction leads to the root of sin, idolatry.
- A God who is distinct, holy, and outside ourselves gives us a standard for right and wrong, just and unjust, love and hate.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Where do you see pantheistic ideas, like karma or a divine force, showing up in movies, music, or wellness culture?
2. Why does the distinction between Creator and creation matter so much? What is lost without it?
3. How does losing that distinction lead to idolatry, even in subtle forms like elevating self, people, or causes?
4. How can we show another worldview is inconsistent while still speaking in love, without making fun of it?

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